

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 51 Summary

Skool.com/qroo

In this lesson, Paul introduces another essential trigger for the Spanish subjunctive: when one action **depends on another occurring first**. This commonly occurs in **time clauses** introduced by **cuando**, as well as **en cuanto** (“as soon as”) and **una vez que** (“once”).

Key Rule

If a sentence has **two clauses** and the action in one **must occur before** the other can happen, the **first action (the one that must happen first)** is expressed using the **subjunctive**.

Trigger pattern:

[Main clause – imperative or future tense] + **cuando / en cuanto / una vez que** + [verb in the subjunctive]

Examples (Present/Future Contexts)

- *Avísame cuando **tengas** la información.*
(Let me know when you have the information.)
→ “Tengas” (subjunctive) is used because the action of obtaining the information must occur before the speaker is notified.
 - *Cenaremos cuando Juan **llegue**.*
(We’ll eat dinner when Juan arrives.)
→ Future action (“we’ll eat”) depends on another future event happening first (“Juan arrives”).
 - *Pensamos ir a la playa cuando **deje de llover**.*
(We plan to go to the beach when it stops raining.)
→ Subjunctive: *deje de llover* (stops raining) must happen before they go.
-

Imperative Constructions

The subjunctive often follows **cuando** in requests or instructions:

- Cuando **tengas** tiempo, ayúdame.
(When you have time, help me.)
- Cuando **recibas** el mensaje, mándamelo.
(When you receive the message, send it to me.)

The **imperative mood** (e.g., *avísame*, *ayúdame*, *mándamelo*) is commonly used in the main clause, and the verb after *cuando* is in the **present subjunctive**.

Habitual Actions: Indicative, Not Subjunctive

If the sentence describes something that happens regularly or habitually, use the **indicative**, not the subjunctive.

- *Siempre nos levantamos cuando el gallo **empieza** a cantar.*
(We always get up when the rooster starts to crow.)
→ Habitual action = indicative mood.

Compare with:

- *Nos levantaremos cuando el gallo **empiece** a cantar.*
(We'll get up when the rooster starts to crow.)
→ Future-dependent action = subjunctive mood.

Look for words like *siempre* (always) or *soler* (to usually do something) to recognize habitual action.

Verb Spotlight: *Soler* – “To Usually Do Something”

Paul introduces *soler* as a useful verb for expressing routine actions. It's followed by an infinitive and conjugated in the present indicative.

Examples:

- *Solemos levantarnos cuando el gallo canta.* – We usually get up when the rooster crows.
 - *Sueles cenar a las seis.* – You usually eat dinner at six.
 - *María suele estudiar todos los días.* – María usually studies every day.
-

More Time Expressions that Trigger the Subjunctive

In addition to *cuando*, these expressions trigger the subjunctive when used with future or imperative contexts:

- **en cuanto** – as soon as
*En cuanto **tenga** la información, te aviso.*
(As soon as I have the information, I'll let you know.)
- **una vez que** – once
*Una vez que **termine**, saldré.*
(Once I finish, I'll leave.)

In casual speech, *cuando* can often substitute these expressions.

Time Expression That *Always* Triggers the Subjunctive: *Antes de que*

Paul clarifies that *antes de que* (“before”) is **not** governed by the same rule. It **always** takes the subjunctive—even with habitual actions.

Examples:

- *Limpio la casa antes de que Juan **llegue**.*
(I clean the house before Juan arrives.)
 - *Siempre limpio la casa antes de que Juan **llegue**.*
(I always clean the house before Juan arrives.)
→ Still subjunctive.
-

Past Tense Usage: Imperfect Subjunctive

When telling a story or referring to completed past actions, the same logic applies—but with the **imperfect subjunctive**.

Example:

- *Le dije que me avisara cuando **llegara**.*
(I told him to let me know when he arrived.)

Here, two subjunctive triggers are present:

1. *Le dije que me avisara* – Imperfect subjunctive from indirect command.

2. *cuando llegara* – Imperfect subjunctive from time clause.

Use this structure to maintain tense agreement in past contexts.

Summary Chart

Context	Time Expression	Mood
Future-dependent	cuando / en cuanto / una vez que	Subjunctive
Habitual actions	cuando / en cuanto / una vez que	Indicative
Always takes subjunctive	antes de que	Subjunctive
Past-time dependence	cuando (in past-tense narration)	Imperfect Subjunctive

Conclusion:

This lesson emphasizes that when one action **must happen first** and you're describing the timing with *cuando* or similar phrases, the first action is placed in the **subjunctive**. By watching for subject changes and considering whether an action is habitual or dependent, you can accurately choose between the **indicative** and **subjunctive** moods in time clauses.